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Into The Wild Essay

The general consensus on Chris McCandless's death was that he was an arrogant, reckless idiot, and he died because of his own idiocy. But was he really all that they said he was? Chris McCandless was an adventurer who hitchhiked to the Stampede Trail and set up shelter in an abandoned bus. He made many questionable decisions that led to his death, such as not taking a map, not taking enough gear to survive out there, and not following the advice of locals. Although he died because of these things, he lived how he wanted, and that in and of itself is noble.

McCandless decided that he would go into the wild with the very few supplies that he had, and that was extremely idiotic and was definitely one of the decisive factors in his death. He went into the wild with the minimal gear he had because he wanted to live a raw life, and, as well as that, he was ignorant. In chapter one, Jim Gallien says, "He wasn't carrying anywhere near as much food and gear as you'd expect a guy to be carrying for that kind of trip." This shows that Chris McCandless went into a rough area without the proper tools that he would need to survive. This fatal flaw of not being prepared led to his death. Ultimately, McCandless was very dumb not to bring adequate supplies that he would need to survive out there, which is why people think he is an idiot.

Chris McCandless's thought was that living a life of safety and conformity was a big waste of time and that you should follow your true adventurous self. Ronald Franz received a letter from Chris McCandless before he went to Alaska that tried to get him to live as Chris did, and also explained why he lived the way he did. On page 40, Chris says, "... nothing is more damaging to the adventurous spirit within a man than a secure future. The very basic core of a man's living spirit is his passion for adventure." This reveals that although Chris McCandless was indeed reckless, he was living how he believed we were meant to live. This also shows that he knew exactly what he was doing when he went out there; he didn't do it without a reason. So, it's easy to call Chris McCandless a reckless idiot, but this shows that he did these things for a noble reason, which is to follow his beliefs.

Another very idiotic thing that Chris McCandless did that led people to think he was a reckless idiot is that he didn't follow the advice of the people who were trying their very best to help him. Jim Galiien, a man who knew the dangers of the Alaskan wilderness and an experienced outdoorsman, could tell that Chris McCandless was extremely unprepared to take on the wild while giving him a ride. On page 7, Jon Krauker says, "Gallien offered to drive Alex (Chris) all the way to Anchorage, buy him some decent gear, and then drive him back to wherever he wanted to go. 'No, thanks anyway,' Alex replied, 'I'll be fine with what I've got.'" As you can see from this, Chris McCandless had many chances to get help from the people who wanted to help him, but he chose not to. It's hard to feel sorry for a guy who refused to let people help him, and it makes his death seem even more tragic because of his own stupidity.

Chris definitely cannot be fit into one category between these two. He wasn't some super noble guy who we should all follow, but he also wasn't an arrogant, reckless idiot who many people think he is. He held his beliefs close to him, and those beliefs led him to do what he did.

But refusing help from people who tried to help him makes me think that he was too confident, which ultimately led to his death.